fellow patient: ‘Remember, education doesn’t make you smarter . . . of course you should study. Study! Only remember for your own sake, it’s not the same as intelligence.’

However much I learned from studying quantum mechanics, I learned almost as much from my more frivolous-seeming activities. I’ve always loved to exercise my mind in unusual ways, and this instinct was served during this period by my starting the Melbourne University Mathematics and Statistics Society Puzzle Hunt. For the first-ever prize hunt, in 2004, we challenged contestants to solve a wacky scenario based around the Australian election and the death of the then Prime Minister. ‘Who hit Howard?’ our promotional material asked. ‘John Howard seems to have been vaporised while giving a secret speech at Melbourne University. Who was behind such a dastardly act and why? What, if anything, does it have to do with grave robberies in marginal electorates, temperature swings and strange night-time goings on under Melbourne University Private?’ There was a serious point to all this silliness, though. As I said at the time, when I spoke to the university newspaper, ‘It’s about thinking clearly and deeply to try to solve a problem.’ In the end a team of statisticians, computer programmers and a musician dug up the $200 prize buried under a garden gnome in the System Garden of the Parkville campus. I know, all this hardly puts me up there with the great hedonists of the age, the great druggists, sexualists and rock and rollers of the period, but, despite what they say in the papers, intellectual playfulness has always been more my thing.

I shared such intellectual adventures with my son. I wanted to protect him from some of the real harshness of the adult world and yet I could see he had good humour. Many parents are, I suppose, frightened of what their children might learn, but I wanted Daniel to follow his own organic growth. By then he would be spending half his time with his mother, and he was great with words, better than I was. There’s always frivolity if you have a child. The pressure of adult life can knock the frivolity out of you, just like a queer storm can blow the wind out of your sails, but I loved the fact that my son was such an optimistic creature. We would go out exploring abandoned buildings together, and, at Christmas one time, we gathered Barbie dolls and toy dragons and blew them up with some homemade explosives and liquid nitrogen.